

we even took a wagon with us to haul our bounty from our treks through the alleys.

One hot summer day when I was heavily pregnant with my fourth child, we hit the mother lode. As I peeled off the proofs of purchase from a group of several diaper boxes set out in the alley I heard a squeal of delight from my two-year-old, Michael. He'd peeked inside one of the boxes and discovered it was packed to the brim with toys! We looked inside the others and realized every single one was filled with Fisher Price Little People, Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles, Lego pieces, and odds and ends of toys that suggested someone had cleaned out an entire playroom. We didn't have our wagon that day so we carried what we could the few blocks home, rushing back to get the remaining boxes. Just as we were about to pick them up, a woman appeared from around the corner of the garage, her arms crossed on her chest, her eyes narrowed to an angry slit.

"Get away from my garbage! That's my garbage."

Busted. I felt a hot blush spreading up to the roots of my hair. "My son saw the toys . . ." I started to say, my voice trailing off at her cold stare. We hastily retreated, our excitement sobered at her extreme reaction. That afternoon, the kids played with the selection of nearly new toys while I filed all the diaper proofs in my file cabinet.

Back then I had an entire room devoted to my hobby, with a desk, a huge shelf, and two file cabinets. The shelf displayed a dozen empty detergent boxes with the lids removed. Those detergent boxes held flattened boxes and larger labels. Some of the flattened boxes could be used several times for different offers; one offer might require a net weight statement, another